

Articles · Present Perfect vs Simple Past · Relative Clauses

Student: Ahmet (Gürkan) · Date: March 2026 · Estimated Time: 1.5 hours

Hi Ahmet,

Wow — what a session! You spoke naturally and confidently with Ifrah about your career, your family, cultural differences between Turkey and Somalia, and your hobbies. Ifrah was genuinely impressed, and so was I.

This homework focuses on three areas that will make your already-strong English even more precise and natural: **(1) articles** — *a, an, the* — which Turkish doesn't have, making them a common challenge; **(2) the Present Perfect vs Simple Past** — two tenses that even advanced learners mix up; and **(3) relative clauses** — the *who / which / that* structures that will help you describe people and things more elegantly. Let's go!

1 GRAMMAR — STUDY & CORRECTIONS

(35 MINUTES)

For each grammar point, (a) study the rule and examples, (b) write an original sentence in the box, and (c) note the rule in your own words.

1.1 Articles — a, an, the, or nothing

× *I am expert in payment engineering.*

× *She is studying at the university.*

× *I like the roads in Izmir.*

✓ *I am **an** expert in pavement engineering.* (a/an = first mention or profession)

✓ *She is studying at **a** university in Istanbul.* (one of many)

✓ *I like roads in Izmir.* (general opinion — no article for general plurals)

✓ *The road we inspected last week was badly damaged.* (the = specific, both speakers know which one)

Rule: Use **a / an** for first mention and general roles. Use **the** for specific, already-known things. Use **no article** for general statements about uncountable or plural things.

▷ **Write two sentences about Geopave — one using *a* or *an* and one using *the* correctly:**

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▷ **Write the rule in your own words:**

1.2 Present Perfect vs Simple Past

- × *I worked for KGM for 30 years. (but you are still active in the field)*
- × *I have graduated from university in 1993. (specific finished time)*
- × *Turkey never developed this field. (true up to today)*
- ✓ *I **have worked** in pavement engineering for over 30 years. (still active — have + past participle)*
- ✓ *I **graduated** from ITU in 1993. (finished event at a specific past time)*
- ✓ *Turkey **has never had** enough pavement engineers. (up to and including now)*
- ✓ *During last year's project, we **collected** 200 data points. (completed project — simple past)*

Rule: Use **Present Perfect** (*have / has + past participle*) for past events still relevant now, experience in your life, or things that started in the past and continue. Use **Simple Past** for completed events at a specific time.

▷ **Write one sentence about your career using the Present Perfect, and one using the Simple Past:**

▷ **Write the rule in your own words:**

1.3 Relative Clauses — who, which, that

- × *The engineer, he helped me with my thesis, retired.*
- × *KGM is a directorate. It manages Turkey's roads.*
- × *Geopave is a company. We founded it in Ankara.*
- ✓ *The engineer **who** helped me with my thesis has retired. (who = for people)*
- ✓ *KGM is a directorate **that** manages Turkey's roads. (that / which = for things)*
- ✓ *Geopave is a company **that** my wife and I founded in Ankara.*
- ✓ *The data **which** we collected last summer showed serious deterioration.*

Rule: Use **who** for people, **which** / **that** for things. The relative clause comes directly after the noun it describes. Do **NOT** repeat the subject pronoun (he, it, we) after the relative pronoun.

▷ **Combine these two sentences into one using a relative clause:**

"Ifrah is a young woman. She lives in Istanbul and studies international trade."

▷ **Write the rule in your own words:**

1.4 Bringing it all together — Error Correction Exercise

The paragraph below contains **6 errors** (articles, tense, and relative clauses). Find them and write the corrected version underneath.

"I have started Geopave three years ago with my wife. She is an engineer, she graduated from the Middle East Technical University. We are an expert in pavement engineering. The road maintenance in Turkey has always been a challenge, but we never gave up. Last year, we developed a new system that it allows us to detect ravelling from photos."

Your corrected version:

2 WRITING TASK — PEOPLE, PLACES & EXPERIENCES

(30 MINUTES)

Write two short paragraphs (4–5 sentences each). Focus on using articles, the Present Perfect, and relative clauses naturally.

Useful Phrase Starters

I have always believed that. . .
The colleague who influenced me most. . .
Samsun is a city that / where. . .
I have never forgotten the time when. . .
It was a decision that I made because. . .
The thing that surprised me most was. . .
She is a person who. . .

Must Include (tick as you use them):

- ☐ at least 3 correct uses of *a / an / the*
- ☐ 1 Present Perfect sentence
- ☐ 1 Simple Past sentence (with a time marker:
in 1993, last year, when I was. . .)
- ☐ 1 relative clause with *who* or *that / which*

Paragraph 1 — Describe Samsun, the city where you grew up. What is it like? What has changed since you lived there? What do you miss?

Paragraph 2 — Think about the most interesting conversation you have had in English recently (perhaps with Ifrah!). Describe the person and what you learned from the exchange.

3 SPEAKING PREPARATION — UNEXPECTED QUESTIONS

(20 MINUTES)

Answer each question in 3–5 sentences. Write naturally, as if speaking. Try to use at least one grammar point from Part 1 in every answer.

Q1: You have been living in Ankara for over 40 years, but you said you would rather live in Izmir. Has anything about Ankara surprised you over the years? What is it about Izmir that you have always loved?

Q2: You mentioned that Turkey lacks pavement engineering expertise. Do you think the situation has improved since you started your career? What has changed, and what still needs to change?

Q3: Ifrah suggested making English learning a hobby. Have you tried any new methods since she gave you that advice? What is something you have watched, read, or listened to in English recently?

Q4: You described yourself as the expert, the manager, and the “office boy” at Geopave. Is there a part of running your own company that you have found harder than you expected? What has been the biggest lesson?

4 BONUS VOCABULARY

(10 MINUTES)

These words and phrases came up in your session or are directly useful for the grammar topics above. Try to use 4–5 in your homework answers!

Section A — Articles & Noun Phrases in Context

#	Word / Expression	Example	Synonyms / Notes
1	a turning point	Starting Geopave was a turning point in my career.	a key moment, a watershed
2	the thing is	The thing is, we don't have enough data-sharing in Turkey.	the problem is, the fact is
3	an eye-opener	Working with Ahsan was an eye-opener for me.	a revelation, a wake-up call
4	a lack of	There is a lack of pavement expertise in Turkey.	a shortage of, an absence of
5	the more... the more	The more I practise, the more confident I become.	comparative structure

Section B — Present Perfect Expressions

#	Word / Expression	Example	Synonyms / Notes
1	so far	So far, I have completed three major road surveys.	up to now, to date
2	ever since	Ever since I founded Geopave, I have worked non-stop.	from that point on
3	have come a long way	My English has come a long way in three months.	have improved greatly
4	have yet to	Turkey has yet to build a national pavement database.	still hasn't, has not managed to
5	it has been + time + since	It has been eight years since Ifrah moved to Istanbul.	time expression with present perfect

Section C — Describing People & Cultural Differences

#	Word / Expression	Example	Synonyms / Notes
1	open-minded	Ifrah is a very open-minded person who is curious about the world.	broad-minded, flexible
2	to come across as	He comes across as confident but modest.	to seem, to appear
3	cultural norm	Asking someone's age is a cultural norm in Turkey.	social custom, convention
4	to adapt to	It takes time to adapt to a new culture.	to adjust to, to get used to
5	upbringing	Her upbringing in Somalia shaped her values.	childhood, background
6	to have in common	We both have a passion for engineering in common.	to share, to both have
7	diverse	Istanbul is a diverse city with people from all backgrounds.	varied, multicultural
8	a sense of belonging	After 8 years, Ifrah has developed a sense of belonging in Istanbul.	feeling at home

★ Mini Challenge (10 minutes)

Choose 3 expressions from the tables above. For each one, write a sentence that also includes a correct article, a relative clause, OR a Present Perfect verb.

1. **Word / Expression:** _____

2. **Word / Expression:** _____

3. **Word / Expression:** _____

Quick Reference: Grammar Summary Table

Structure	Example	Common Error	Fix
a / an	I met a professor. She is an expert.	I met professor.	Add a/an before singular nouns
the	The university I attended was in Ankara.	I attended university in Ankara.	Use <i>the</i> for specific/known things
no article	I like roads. (general)	I like the roads. (which roads?)	No article for general plurals
Present Perfect	I have worked for KGM for 30 years.	I worked for KGM for 30 years.	Use have + p.p. for ongoing past
Simple Past	I graduated from ITU in 1993.	I have graduated in 1993.	Use past simple for finished events
Relative clause	The engineer who advised me retired.	The engineer, he advised me, retired.	who/which/that replaces he/it